catastrophic repercussions. On 23 January 1961 an airborne alerted B-52 crashed near Goldsboro in North Carolina. It was carrying two four-megaton yield Mark 39 thermonuclear bombs. One of these was never recovered. Schlosser explains what happened with the other:

> Every safety mechanism had failed, except one: the ready/safe switch in the cockpit. The switch was in the SAFE position when the bomb dropped. Had the switch been set to GROUND or AIR, the X-unit would've charged, the detonators would've triggered, and a thermonuclear weapon would have exploded in a field near Faro, North Carolina.[6]

With strong northerly winds, Schlosser explains, a ground-burst would have sent lethal radioactive fallout over Washington, Baltimore, Philadelphia, and New York.

Beyond the horrifying civilian casualties, there was an even more frightening possibility. In *Dark Beyond Darkness* (undoubtedly the most imaginative book written about the Cuban missile crisis), James Blight and janet Lang present a scenario in which the Goldsboro accident leads to the very brink of nuclear war.[7]President Kennedy is evacuated from the White House. Robert McNamara tells him that a thermonuclear explosion has killed tens of thousands and created radioactive fallout that is heading toward US cities, where millions more will likely die. McNamara does not know what caused the explosion. General Curtis LeMay is certain that the United States has been attacked by the Soviet Union. He demands a full retaliatory attack to forestall further Soviet strikes. He also makes clear that even if the Soviets are not responsible, the United States should still seize the opportunity to prevent future Soviet attacks. In Moscow, Khrushchev's military advisers are certain that the US will blame the Soviet Union. Accordingly, they recommend pre-emptive attacks on the United States, to use, rather than lose the Soviet nuclear arsenal. The scenario ends there.

Avowed policy